

THE RIGHT CONNECT

The chief minister has launched a Mission 2008 to help him win a second term

■ By Ambresh Mishra

A chief minister's visit to any dusty, non-descript village is a spectacle like no other as he has the entire government machinery ready to do his bidding. In Madhya Pradesh, the office has come with an added advantage for Shivraj Singh Chauhan—that of political stability.

Unstinted support from the party high command and near-total absence of in-house dissidence has allowed Chauhan to launch Mission 2008, aimed at recapturing power in the next Assembly polls—something no previous BJP chief minister has managed to accomplish in the state. The cornerstone of his strategy is a visit to each of the 48 districts in the state at least twice before the elections in December 2008 to connect directly with the masses. Jan Darshan isn't a new formula, having been tried first by Digvijay Singh and then by Uma Bharati with varying degrees of success. What sets Chauhan's weekend rural sorties apart is the method that follows his mingling with the teeming crowds.

Since the first Jan Darshan in tribal-dominated Sidhi district on this year's Republic Day, the exercise has grown into part social audit of development works and part grievance redressal mechanism. The follow-up of complaints made to him by people during surprise visits to villages starts with the district administration officials on the night of the exercise and continues into the wee hours.

During the Jan Darshan in Jhabua district's Antarveliya village in June, he took up a list of labourers employed under a scheme promoting construction of irrigation tanks on farmland and called out five of them to check the payments they had been getting. When they reported underpayment, the errant officials were suspended on the spot. "The

CROWD PULLER: Chauhan mingles freely with the masses



PANKAJ TIWARI